The Product Management Career Lab

2.23.2026
PDL @ Columbia Engineering
Micah Berman / micahberman.com

A few brave **volunteers...**

What is your **name**?
What is one of your **favorite products**?
One sentence on **why**?

Supplement a world-class Columbia education with the
context and skills to **pick**, **land**, and **grow**
a Product Management career
in today’s dynamic environment

I’m honored to pay it forward

- 11 years at Google - Search, Google.org AI, and Android - managing products and teams from 0 to 1 to 2B+
- 2 years as a venture-backed startup founder, starting from scratch and raising $M’s in venture funding
- Conducted 100’s of interviews
- My career has been on software, and so this talk is heavily software-focused

Google

Google.org

android

EZRA.

Today, we'll cover:

(1) **Pick**

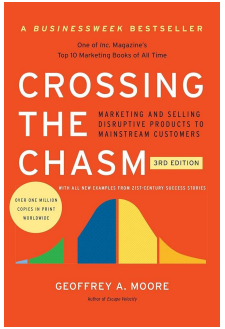
What product management is and is not, theoretically and practically, to decide if PM is a good fit for you and your goals

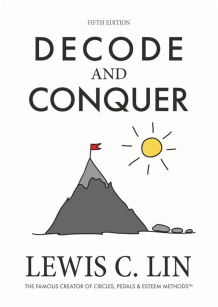
(2) **Land**

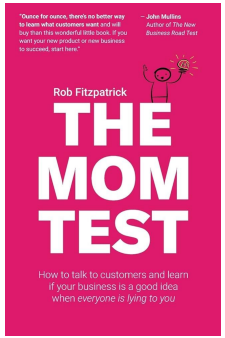
The 3 cornerstones of landing a job in product management, with a focus on interview skills, plus a few mini practice interviews under your belt

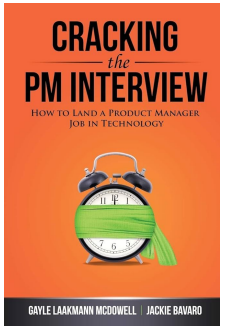
(3) **Grow**

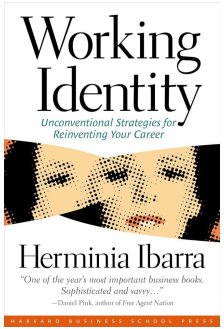
Tools to win the early days and shape a long-term career arc

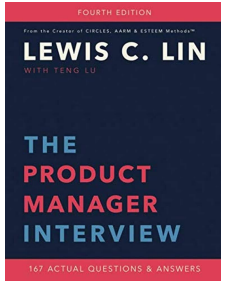

A BUSINESSWEEK BESTSELLER
One of Inc. Magazine's Top 10 Marketing Books of All Time
CROSSING THE CHASM
MARKETING AND SELLING DISRUPTIVE PRODUCTS TO MAINSTREAM CUSTOMERS
3RD EDITION
WITH ALL NEW EXAMPLES FROM 21ST-CENTURY SUCCESS STORIES
OVER ONE MILLION COPIES IN PRINT WORLDWIDE
GEOFFREY A. MOORE
Author of Escape Velocity

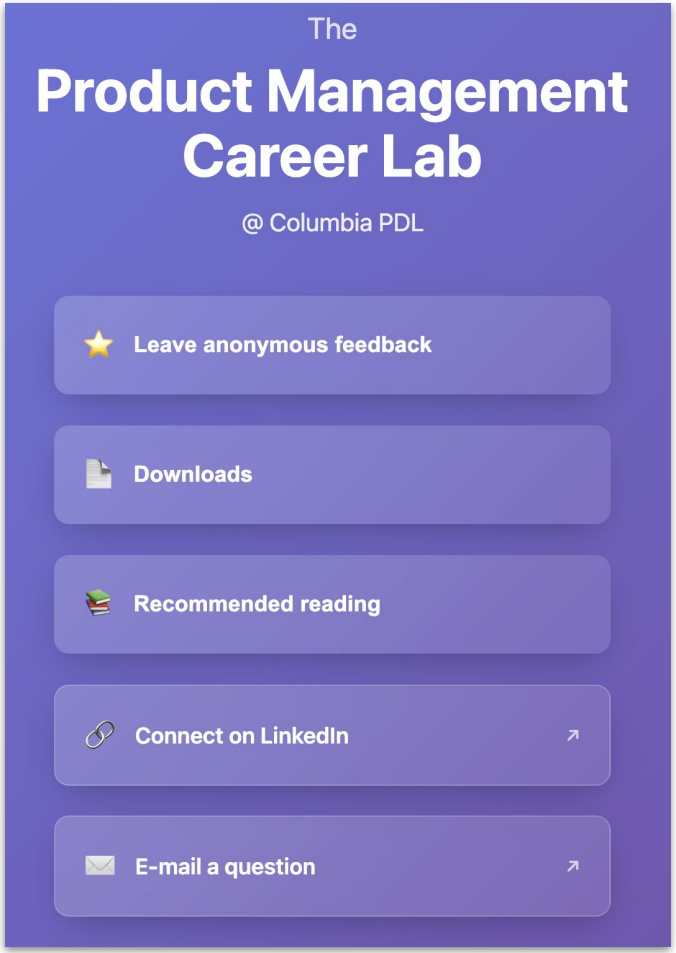

FIFTH EDITION
DECODE AND CONQUER
LEWIS C. LIN
THE FAMOUS CREATOR OF CIRCLES, PEDALS & ESTEEM METHODS™


"Ounce for ounce, there's no better way to learn what customers want and will buy than this wonderful little book. If you want your new product or new business to succeed, start here."
– John Mullins
Author of The New Business Road Test
Rob Fitzpatrick
THE MOM TEST
How to talk to customers and learn if your business is a good idea when everyone is lying to you


CRACKING the PM INTERVIEW
How to Land a Product Manager Job in Technology
GAYLE LAAKMANN MCDOWELL | JACKIE BAVARO


Working Identity
Unconventional Strategies for Reinventing Your Career
Herminia Ibarra
"One of the year's most important business books. Sophisticated and savvy…"
—Daniel Pink, author of Free Agent Nation
HARVARD BUSINESS SCHOOL PRESS


FOURTH EDITION
From the Creator of CIRCLES, AARM & ESTEEM Methods™
LEWIS C. LIN
WITH TENG LU
THE PRODUCT MANAGER INTERVIEW
167 ACTUAL QUESTIONS & ANSWERS



micahberman.com/careerlab

Pick > Land > Grow

What product management is and is not, theoretically and practically, to decide if PM is a good fit for you and your goals.

Activity Preview

At the end of this section, there will be a 3 minute reflection:

- What appeals to you?...
- How does this align with your strengths?...
- What are pros/cons of PM versus other career paths...

How it started

1931

C O P Y MARKETING - Brand Teams, 1931

cc: Mr. W. G. Werner

Mr. N. H. McElroy

Mr. R. F. Rogan

May 13, 1931

ADV**N. H. MCELROY

Because I think it may be of some help to you in putting through our recommendation for additional men for the Promotion Department, I am outlining briefly below the duties and responsibilities of the brand men.

This outline does not represent the situation as it is but as we will have it when we have sufficient man power. In past years the brand men have been forced to do work that should have been passed on to assistant brand men, if they had been available and equal to the job.

Brand Man

(1) Study carefully shipments of his brands by units:

(2) Where brand development is heavy and where it is progressing, examine carefully the combination of effort that seems to be clicking and try to apply this same treatment to other territories that are comparable.

(3) Where brand development is light

(a) Study the past advertising and promotional history of the brand; study the territory personally at first hand - both dealers and consumers - in order to find out the trouble.

(b) After uncovering our weakness, develop a plan that can be applied to this local sore spot. It is necessary, of course, not simply to work out the plan but also to be sure that the amount of money proposed can be expected to produce results at a reasonable cost per case.

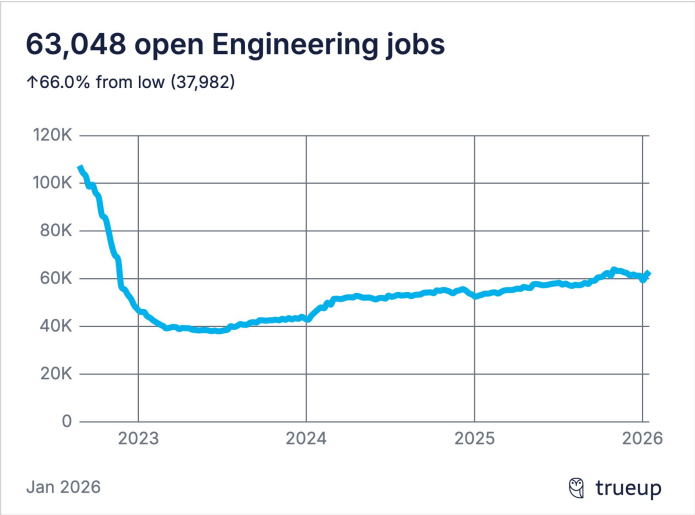
(c) Outline this plan in detail to the Division Manager under whose jurisdiction the weak territory is, obtain his authority and support for the corrective action.

How it’s going

2026

PM

SWE

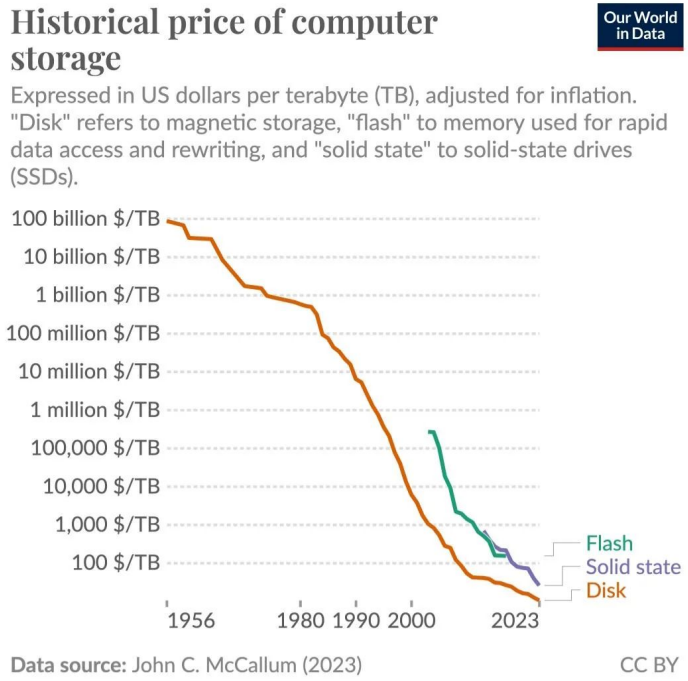


~~Prediction:~~ **AI** is **enabling** human PM work

Today: the *inputs* to PM become cheaper: customer understanding, rapid prototyping, documentation, development velocity (Lovable, Figma Make, and GPTs), plus an explosion of AI-first jobs.

Tomorrow: as the cost of *building* trends toward zero, as software commoditizes, judgement about *what* and *why* to build differentiates, and *how* becomes critical: *reliability, integrations, usability, support*.

Bonus: what *is* an AI PM?



So, what **do PMs do**?

Deliver products that users love.

But **what** do they actually **do?**

What

- Responsible for **the result**
- Build bridges from **problem** to **solution**
- Difference between **good and great** - organizations don't *need* PMs
- **CEO** and the **janitor**, in one
- A team's **representative** to the world, inside and out
- Makes **ambiguity actionable**, always without enough data

And **how** do they do it?

What

- Responsible for **the result**
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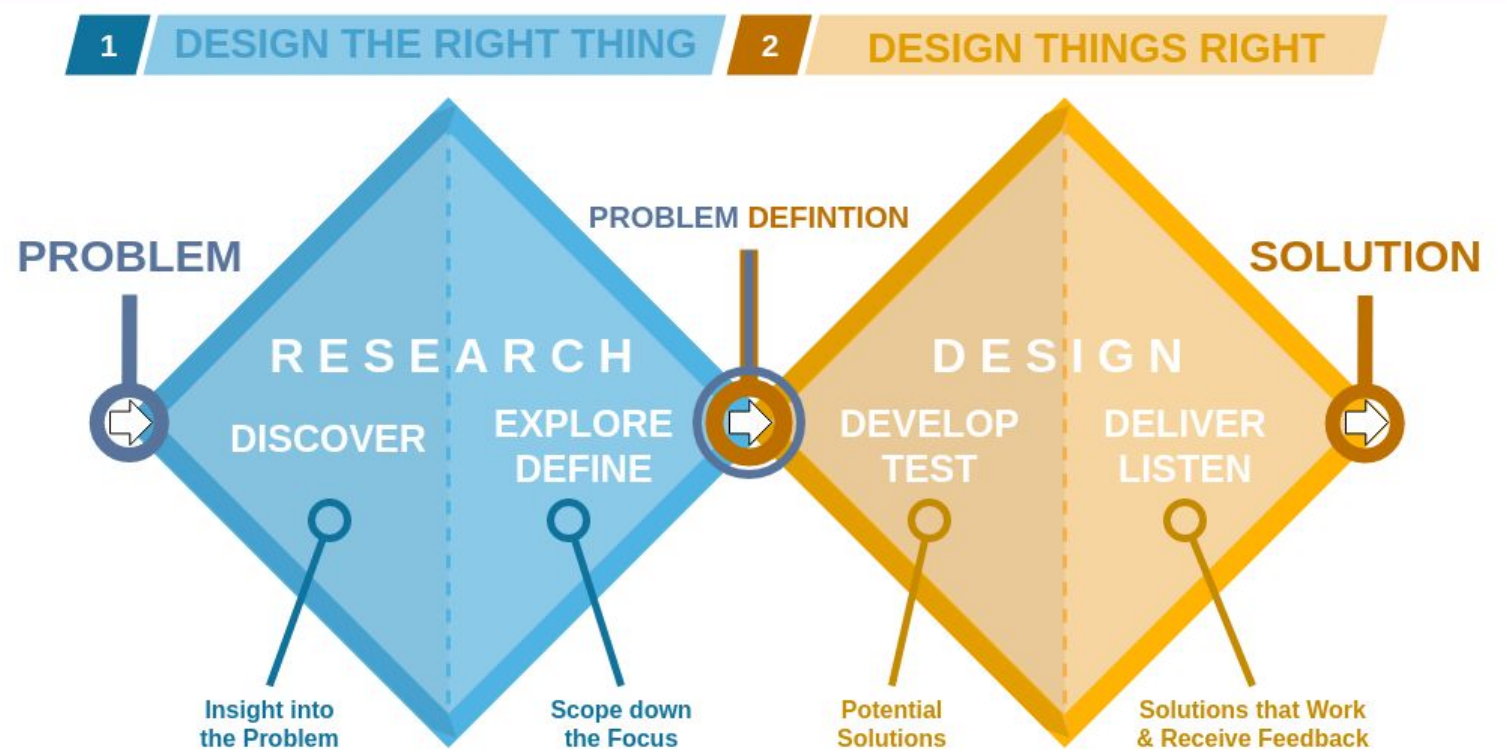
How

- Leadership **without authority** to get everyone on the same page
- **Customer** voice (not customer gofer) to focus on what matters
- **Glue** between teams with fluent and clear **communication** across disciplines
- Forest and trees **together** to prioritize
- Saying **"no"** with conviction to drive the most important work

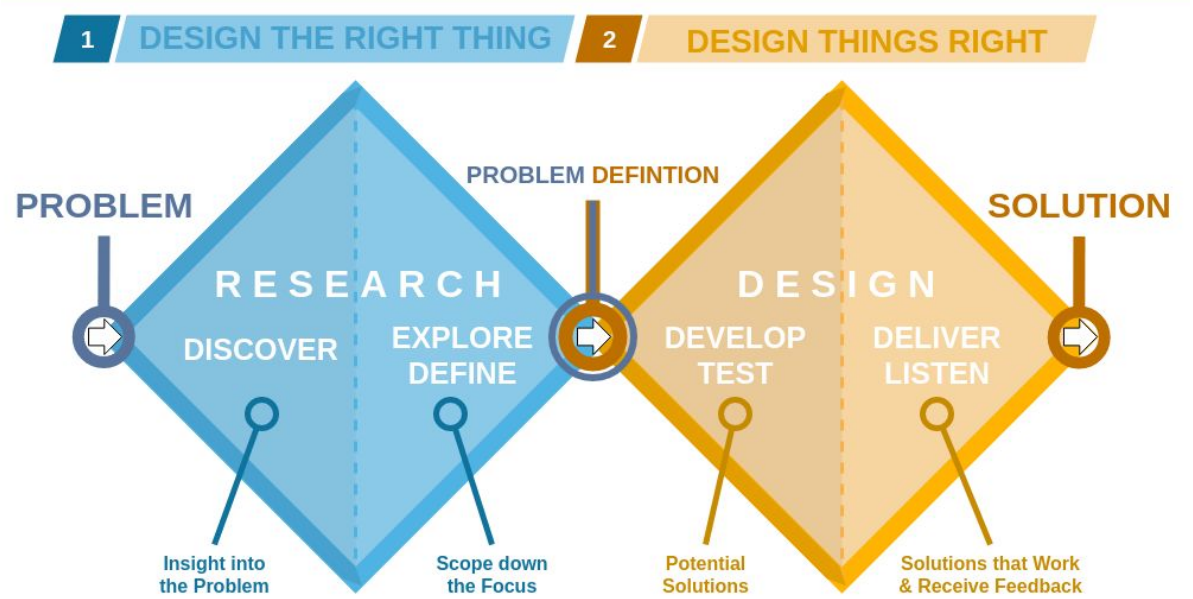
Guide the **product development process**



https://www.innovationtraining.org/design-thinking-double-diamond-framework-training/

Guide the **product development process**

Claude
CURSOR
outset.ai



Make
Lovable
replit
n8n

https://www.innovationtraining.org/design-thinking-double-diamond-framework-training/

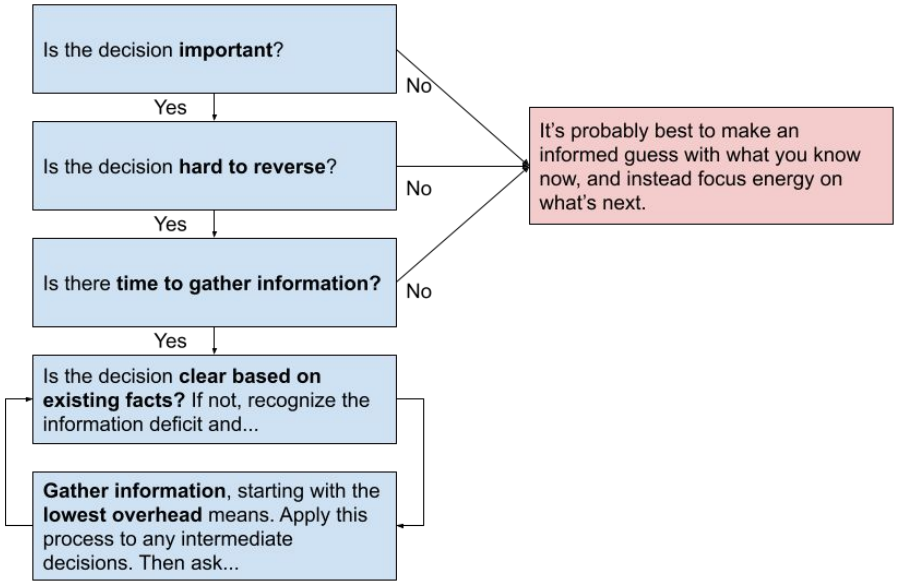
Answers and decisions

As a PM, you won't know all of the answers, but your team counts on you for decisions. You skill is knowing where, when, and how to find information; how to decide; and how important it all is.

Hard Decisions as Information Deficits

This is the critical reframing: there are not *hard decisions*, there are only information deficits. Think about the last "hard decision" you made, and now imagine it was in a world with perfect information about the past, present, and future. Would it still have been hard?

This charts presents a way to feel empowered the next time you encounter a "hard decision".



⚽ PM **vs other functions**

- **Product management**
  What game are we playing? What counts as a goal, and how many points is it worth?

- **Design**
  What do the plays look like? How can we make them easy to run?

- **Program management**
  What is the order of plays we run, when will we run them, and how will we track them? What's the score? How much time is left?

- **Engineering**
  On the field, playing the game. Engineering managers quarterback.

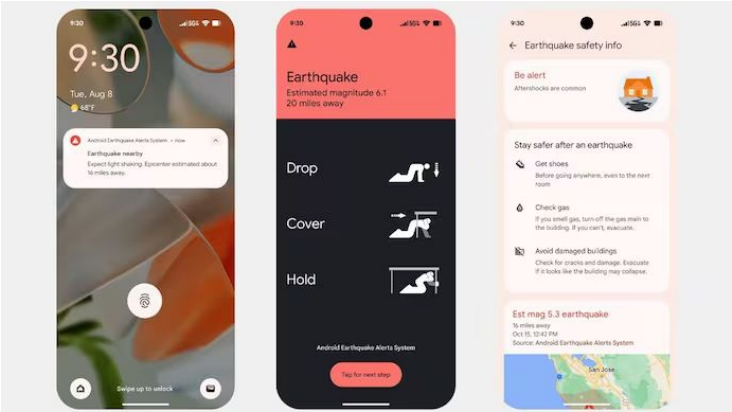
- **Marketing, Communications, and Government Relations**
  Defensive and offensive strategists, announcers and commentators, publicists

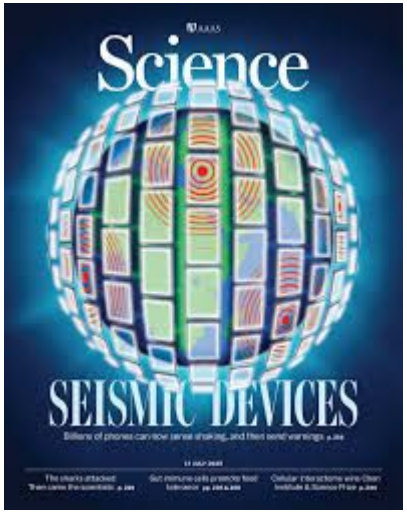
Big Co example: scaling EEW

Product: earthquake detection and alerting using a network of Android smartphones

Mission: provide the most accurate, earliest warning to as many users as possible.

Challenge: go from a beta product in just a few countries to one live across the globe.

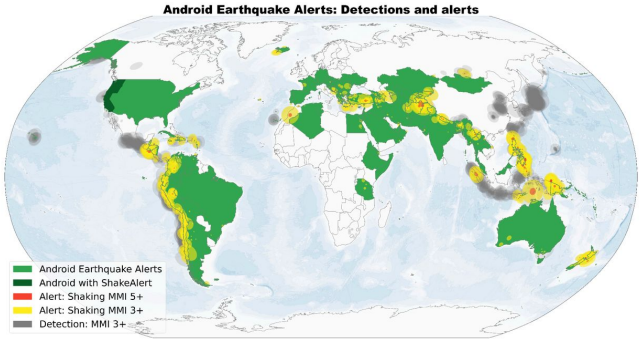




Big Co example: scaling EEW

Over ~8 months, we **grew the product from <10 countries to >90 countries, protecting 1B+ users** with a **decrease** in false positives.

- **Defined goals and plan**, in consultation with outside experts
- Designed, built, and launched **new alerts** to address markets, languages, guidance
- Developed framework to **evaluate algo accuracy**, made substantial leaps forward
- Lobbied for **internal resourcing**
- Ran a 3-tranche **rollout strategy** based on risk, impact, legal climate
- Monitored and iterated via **new feedback mechanism** and infrastructure
- **Publicized** launch with the media and scientific communities



Startup example: banking integration

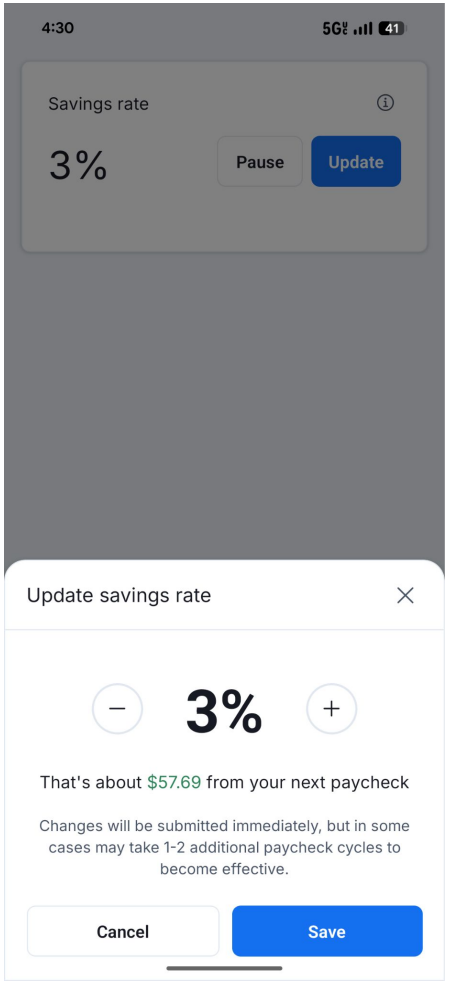
Product: payroll-integrated emergency savings app for frontline workers

Mission: provide the easiest-to-use, most beneficial savings product to as many frontline workers are we can

Challenge: convincing large partners in a complex ecosystem to build with a tiny company; charting a tractable, fast path through a complex space

Startup example: banking integration

- Used networks to find **experts to interview** about the constraints and options
- **Evaluated** 3-4 different approaches, each with different risk/reward trade-offs
- **Canvassed** 70+ partner banks and API integration paths, negotiated terms
- **Drafted and implemented** all user flows in collaboration with founding engineer, optimizing as we went
- **Tracked and met launch requirements** from partners, including legal and compliance infrastructure
- **Hired a team** of expert contractors to execute
- **Launched and tested live with pilot customers**, spending time onsite to observe behavior and conduct interviews



How does PM differ by company size?

	Systems and support	Autonomy	Predictability and security	Growth potential	Product lifecycle
Big tech (FAANG)	High	Low	High	Slow	Design / develop/ deliver
Speciality tech (Unicorns)	Medium	Medium	Medium	Fast	Design / develop / deliver
Startup Later stage (>B)	Low	High	Medium	Fastest	Full scope
Startup Early stage (<B)	Very low	Extreme	Low	Varies w/ PMF	Full scope

A Tuesday in the life...

Big Co PM

- London team standup
- Legal : PM RE: launch
- ELS team meeting
- Sync re: FCC inquiry
- Exec weekly launch review
- Lunch w/ PM team
- EEW algo team sync
- 1:1 w/ manager
- UXR findings review
- Australia team standup

Small Startup PM

- Onsite with customer
- Whiteboard a new feature with eng lead
- Answering support emails
- Eng/PM daily sync
- Helping figure out why prod is broken again

Finding a role

What you're looking for...

- Great **managers** or leadership you want to follow?
- What **learning style** do you want? (from the best, vs by doing)
- How important is **stability**?
- How important is **growth** - and what kind?
- How important are **values** and **mission** alignment?

... should guide **where** you look:

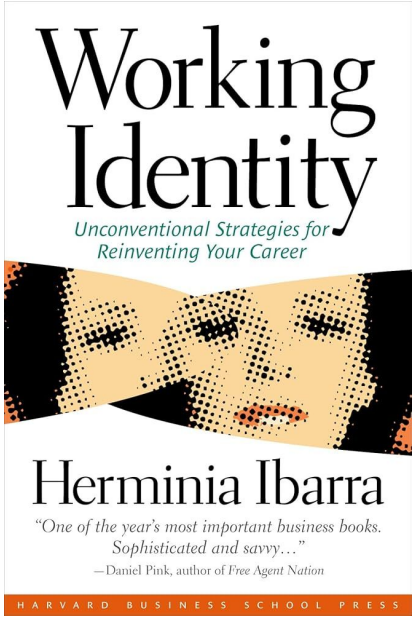
- Job boards at big and mid-size organizations
- LinkedIn, Indeed, or specialist (eg, biotech) job boards for the long tail
- Idealist, All Tech Is Human, and Probably Good for impact-oriented

A note on picking

Working Identities, by Hermina Ibarra

In short, **try it** with **slowly escalating commitment.**

- Discovery is active - rather than thinking, figure out *what is easiest and most promising* to test - and then escalate tests in level of commitment
- The path is crooked - accept that change is not immediate and *requires progressive steps*
- Don't "find" your true self - *explore one or more possible version* of the future
- Take a *portfolio approach* - select a few foci and run small experiments in each



Reflection Activity

3 minutes on the clock...

Grab a paper, doc or phone note:

- What appeals to you? What doesn't? What else do you want to know?
- How does this align with your strengths? Where would you like to grow?
- What are pros/cons of PM versus other career paths you're considering?

Pick > **Land** > Grow

The 3 cornerstones of landing a job in product management, with a focus on interview skills, plus a few practice interviews under your belt.

Activity Preview

At the end of this section, we'll spend a total of 45 minutes practicing two mini cases each as interviewer and interviewee.

Landing the job: 3 steps

1. **Build a network**
   → Gets your resume to the right people

2. Create compelling collateral
   → Gets you an interview

3. Ace the interview
   → Gets you a job

Building a network

The point: learn, get your resume reviewed
What you need: a reason for them to help, a clear request

Start where you already are or have been:

- Alumni networks (Columbia, undergrad, high school)
- Previous employers
- Your neighborhood
- Sports teams
- Hobbies
- Use your network to build a network (LinkedIn second degree connections)

Using a network

Ask for:

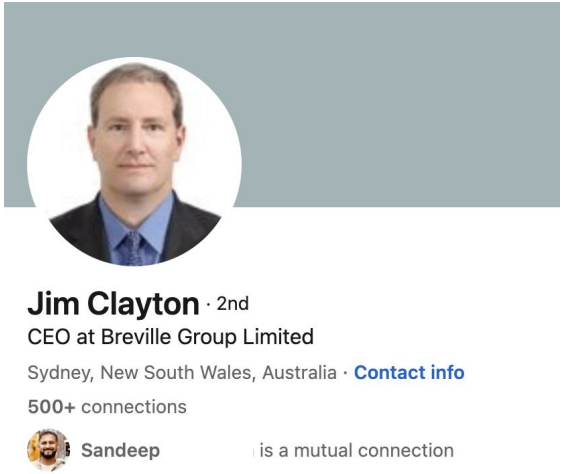
- Informational interviews about a field or profession
- Questions about a role
- A referral for a specific opening
- Introductions to others for any of the above

In all cases, make the case and make their life easy:

1. Keep your connection top-of-mind
   "Have you been back to Columbia since you graduated? Campus hasn't changed much!"

2. Research in order to be specific, and include a "why"
   "Would love an intro to Nika on your team - I admire her work on emerging toasting technologies, especially her latest article in Cooking Science. I saw she's hiring and would love to see if there's a fit."

3. Include a blurb for easy forwarding



Landing the job: 3 steps

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Creating compelling collateral

The point: help you get an interview.
What you need: **skimmable impact** that shows a recruiter or founder your **ability** and **fit**
Where it goes: (1) Your resume, customized for the job; (2) LinkedIn; (3) potentially a cover letter

- **Your resume is a product deliverable**. Put your best PM skills to work: structure, prioritization, customization, accuracy
- Read in **~15 seconds** (by a human) or less (by an LLM), mostly looking for words/phrases (*unless* you've got a referral!), so use some of their words from the job description
- **Talk other experience** into PM terms – be creative
- **One page**, period
- **Brief, specific bullets** about *the impact (you) had*, emphasis on *what's relevant* based on the job/company description
    - No: "Responsible for growing userbase"
    - Yes: "Led onboarding redesign that grew DAUs 300% YoY"
- If there's a cover letter, use it to **connect your skills/experience to being a hand-in-glove fit** for the role. Short and sweet.

10 seconds: what do you make of this resume?

First Name, Last Name
Email, Contact, Linkedin

SUMMARY
Product Manager with 3 years of experience leading impactful features for large-scale consumer social media platforms. Spearheaded the development of a 'music-in-feed' feature, which enabled users to enhance their posts with music, driving a +1.3% increase in daily user content and generating over a billion music-enhanced posts. Eager to leverage my expertise in product innovation and user engagement to contribute to a dynamic, growth-oriented consumer tech company.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE
Product Manager **| Major Tech Company | San Francisco, CA | July 2022 – Present**
Advanced within the company while taking on increasing responsibilities. Initially served as one of three product managers on a social media team, where I led a workstream of three engineers and a designer to introduce music to the platform through features like 'music-in-feed.' Currently, as the sole Product Manager on the Creator Support team, I lead a team of 11 engineers and cross-functional partners to address content moderation issues, developing solutions such as strike relaxation, self-remediation, and video appeals. These initiatives collectively increased daily content posted by creators by +0.6% and boosted monetizable views by +1.2%.

- **Vision and Roadmapping:** Managed and balanced requests from senior leadership with feedback from product and integrity teams. Oversaw brainstorming and prioritization of over twenty projects to drive increased daily creator content and monetizable views.
- **Creative Solutions:** Proposed an innovative idea allowing users to add music to feed posts, resulting in a +3.2% increase in daily feed content [illegible] teams.
- **Team Leadership:** Fostered a collab[illegible] effective meetings, organizing offsites, and enhancing operations. Consistently [illegible] strong team chemistry and leading with a positive attitude.
- **Agile Methodologies:** Delivered multiple projects including video appeals and self-remediation using Agile and Scrum frameworks, all successfully launched on schedule.
- **Stakeholder Management:** Led discussions with leadership and cross-functional teams to align on initiatives centered on creator monetization and user experience, while mitigating integrity concerns.
- **User Research:** Collaborated with researchers to design surveys and conduct interviews with users. Insights helped shape the product roadmap, resulting in successful feature launches.

Financial Operations Analyst **| Finance Firm, New York, NY Summer 2021**
Played a key role in a four-person team developing a unified commissions system, streamlining operations across financial instruments. This initiative increased process efficiency by 15%.

Business Analyst **| Consulting Firm | New York, NY | Summer 2019 & 2020**
Worked with a state government to enhance contact tracing during the COVID-19 pandemic. Recommended improvements to tech services, resulting in a 35% increase in tracing efficiency.

Board Member **| State Board of Education | Sacramento, CA | July 2017 – July 2018**
Appointed by the Governor to represent 6.2 million students in California K-12 education as one of 11 members of the state board. Voted on topics concerning school accountability, curriculum, assessment, and charter schools.

EDUCATION
State University, United States
Bachelor of Arts in Economics, May 2022

AFFILIATIONS, SKILLS & INTERESTS
Skills: Python, Java, Adobe Products, Excel, Public Speaking
Interests: Consumer Tech, Social Media Content Creation, Music & Music Production

Ready?

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

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- **Team Leadership:** Fostered a collaborative environment by driving effective meetings, organizing offsites, and enhancing operations. Consistently received high praise for building strong team chemistry and leading with a positive attitude.
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Source: Exponent

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- **Stakeholder Management:** Led discussions with leadership and cross-functional teams to align on initiatives centered on creator monetization and user experience, while mitigating integrity concerns.
- **User Research:** Collaborated with researchers to design surveys and conduct interviews with users. Insights helped shape the product roadmap, resulting in successful feature launches.

Financial Operations Analyst **| Finance Firm, New York, NY Summer 2021**
Played a key role in a four-person team developing a unified commissions system, streamlining operations across financial instruments. This initiative increased process efficiency by 15%.

Business Analyst **| Consulting Firm | New York, NY | Summer 2019 & 2020**
Worked with a state government to enhance contact tracing during the COVID-19 pandemic. Recommended improvements to tech services, resulting in a 35% increase in tracing efficiency.

Board Member **| State Board of Education | Sacramento, CA | July 2017 – July 2018**
Appointed by the Governor to represent 6.2 million students in California K-12 education as one of 11 members of the state board. Voted on topics concerning school accountability, curriculum, assessment, and charter schools.

EDUCATION
State University, United States
Bachelor of Arts in Economics, May 2022

AFFILIATIONS, SKILLS & INTERESTS
Skills: Python, Java, Adobe Products, Excel, Public Speaking
Interests: Consumer Tech, Social Media Content Creation, Music & Music Production

Time's up!

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

***Product Manager* | Major Tech Company | San Francisco, CA | July 2022 – Present**

Advanced within the company while taking on increasing responsibilities. Initially served as one of three product managers on a social media team, where I led a workstream of three engineers and a designer to introduce music to the platform through features like 'music-in-feed.' Currently, as the sole Product Manager on the Creator Support team, I lead a team of 11 engineers and cross-functional partners to address content moderation issues, developing solutions such as strike relaxation, self-remediation, and video appeals. These initiatives collectively increased daily content posted by creators by +0.6% and boosted monetizable views by +1.2%.

- **Vision and Roadmapping:** Managed and balanced requests from senior leadership with feedback from product and integrity teams. Oversaw brainstorming and prioritization of over twenty projects to drive increased daily creator content and monetizable views.
- **Creative Solutions:** Proposed an innovative idea allowing users to add music to feed posts, resulting in a +3.2% increase in daily feed content from teens.
- **Team Leadership:** Fostered a collaborative environment by driving effective meetings, organizing offsites, and enhancing operations. Consistently received high praise for building strong team chemistry and leading with a positive attitude.
- **Agile Methodologies:** Delivered multiple projects including video appeals and self-remediation using Agile and Scrum frameworks, all successfully launched on schedule.
- **Stakeholder Management:** Led discussions with leadership and cross-functional teams to align on initiatives centered on creator monetization and user experience, while mitigating integrity concerns.
- **User Research:** Collaborated with researchers to design surveys and conduct interviews with users. Insights helped shape the product roadmap, resulting in successful feature launches.

Source: Exponent

Landing the job: 3 steps

1. Build a network
   → Gets your resume to the right people

2. Create compelling collateral
   → Gets you an interview

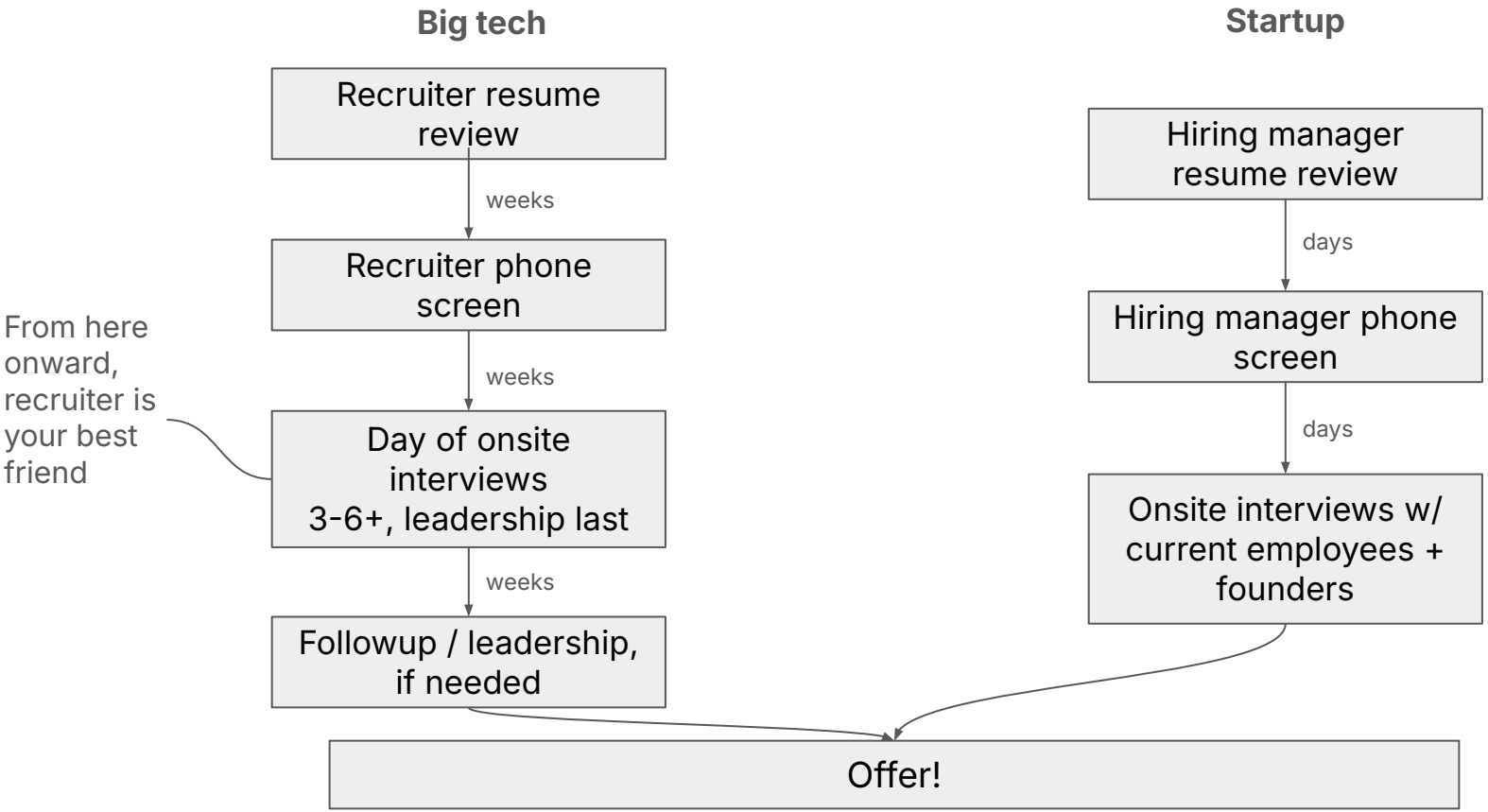
3. **Ace the interview**
   → Gets you a job

Interview preparation

The point: demonstrate you can do the job
What you need: show off structured, rigorous, creative thinking

- **Practice, practice, practice…** then practice more. There is no substitute.
  - At *least* 20 practice interviews – but 20 *of each category* isn't a bad idea
  - You are building intuition and context when, inevitably, the question is different than you expected
  - Use classmates, friends, family, online study groups, or LLMs for practice interviews
- Craft **a plan and schedule** that you can stick to
- **Customize your prep** for each company and role
  - If you were interviewing to be the CEO, you'd need opinions going in
  - Download their product, test their competitors, read about the market, revenue model, recent announcements, study their mission, learn their culture/values
  - Think about the context: why might they be hiring? What are their biggest challenges? What are they likely to be worried about?

A typical interview flow



What’s happening on the other side of the table?

Big tech

- Recruiters screen candidates and refer to standardized interview process
- **Interviewers often from general pool** (at least 1, sometimes all, from non-target teams). Blind, standardized scoring in internal tool
- Hiring **committee** or equivalent makes decision, often with limits on control of hiring team and single-member veto

Startup

- **Hold informal checkins** following each interview and/or round to shape next conversations
- Likely interviewing **with the people you’d be working with**. Often use less formal evaluation frameworks
- Often **cofounder**(s) are decisionmakers, with input from teams at larger startups; many 1k+ FTE founders still personally review each hire

On-site interview components

An example 45-minute interview:

- Interviewer setup and intro (2 minutes)
- Behavioral intro (~5 minutes)
  - “Tell me about yourself”
  - A warmup/bridge question
- Quick scenario (~8 mins)
- Deep-dive scenario (~20 mins)
- Questions for interviewer (~5 mins)

Primary interview types

- **Behavioral**
- Product
  - Design
  - Strategy
- Analytical
  - Estimation
  - Debugging
- Technical
  - Algorithms
  - Systems design

Behavioral

Master examples in advance to focus on delivering strategic answers with precision.

Questions are just talking point opportunities: think about what's behind the question for the interviewer, and the stories that you want to share.

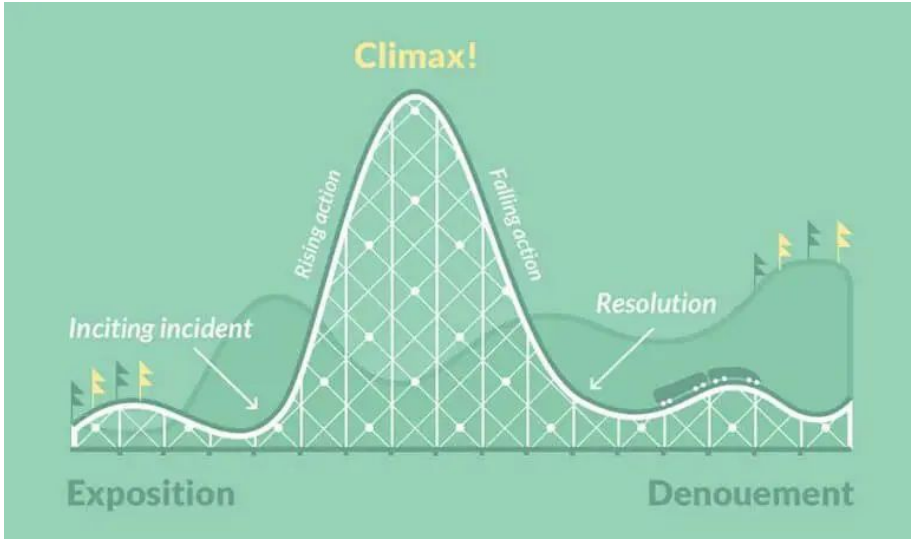
- Pitching Tell me about yourself... Why this company / role? Where do you see yourself in N years?
- Leadership A decision you made that wasn't popular?
- Challenges A time when you didn't have the data you needed to make a decision. What'd you do next?
- Mistakes and failures
- Successes
- Teamwork A time when two peers disagreed about the path forward. How did you resolve it?

- *Drilldown on anything that's on your resume*

The (N)SAR Framework

To keep answers focused, you can use SAR:

- **Nugget** - one-phrase summary
- **Situation** - what was going on?
- **Action** - what did you do?
- **Result** - what did that create?



Primary on-site interview types

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- **Product**
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The power of structure

How would you grow user share?

“Okay, that’s a good question. Well, one thing I’d focus on is marketing ... and, hmmm, another thing, the onboarding flow. And how about... actually, do we have any metrics on retention?”

vs...

The power of structure

How would you grow user share?

“Okay, that’s a good question. Well, one thing I’d focus on is marketing ... and, hmmm, another thing, the onboarding flow. And how about... actually, do we have any metrics on retention?”

vs

“Great question. Give me just a moment to think about it... Okay, there are 3 threads we should pursue: marketing, onboarding, and retention. I’ll review each in turn, and then outline pros/cons of each change and how to prioritize them. Is there any particular area you’d like me to focus on? Otherwise, I’ll dig in with marketing.”

The best candidates

1. **Structure, waypost, and summarize** - chart a path for your interviewer, and then lead them along it explicitly. Begin with and end with a summary

2. **Take the lead, think aloud, and collaborate** - lead, but get your interviewer on your team
   "Okay, I'm thinking this would be very simple if we knew the capacity of the number of WiFi APs in MSG. We could assume 10,000, unless you know?"

3. **Co-manage time** with the interviewer – forest and trees
   "I know we have just 10 minutes left - how about I quickly summarize our approach to users?"

4. **Don't get discouraged or stuck** - if cut off, move on; if stuck, use a placeholder and keep going

5. **Use frameworks as inspiration**, not a rote exercise

The basic shape: CASAS

CASAS is an easy, broadly-applicable approach to any product-related question

If you're ever in doubt, or drawing a blank, it's a good idea to come back ***home***

It's fine to take a (brief) pause

A bad decision or assumption makes little impact if it's couched in great structure

- Clarify
  - Ask for any assumptions
- Approach / User Needs
  - State hypotheses, use metaphors
- Solution
  - Defend, and then highlight flaws
- Alternatives
  - What else might you do? Pros/cons for bonus points
- Success
  - Implementation (eng, GTM, business model)
  - Metrics

Product Design

These look like:

- **Design X for Y**
  - A subway pass for elderly users
  - A hotel for 4-year-olds
  - A car for dogs
- What would you improve about X
  - What would you improve about GMail?
- What is your favorite product and why?

If you need an “innovative” idea, consider:

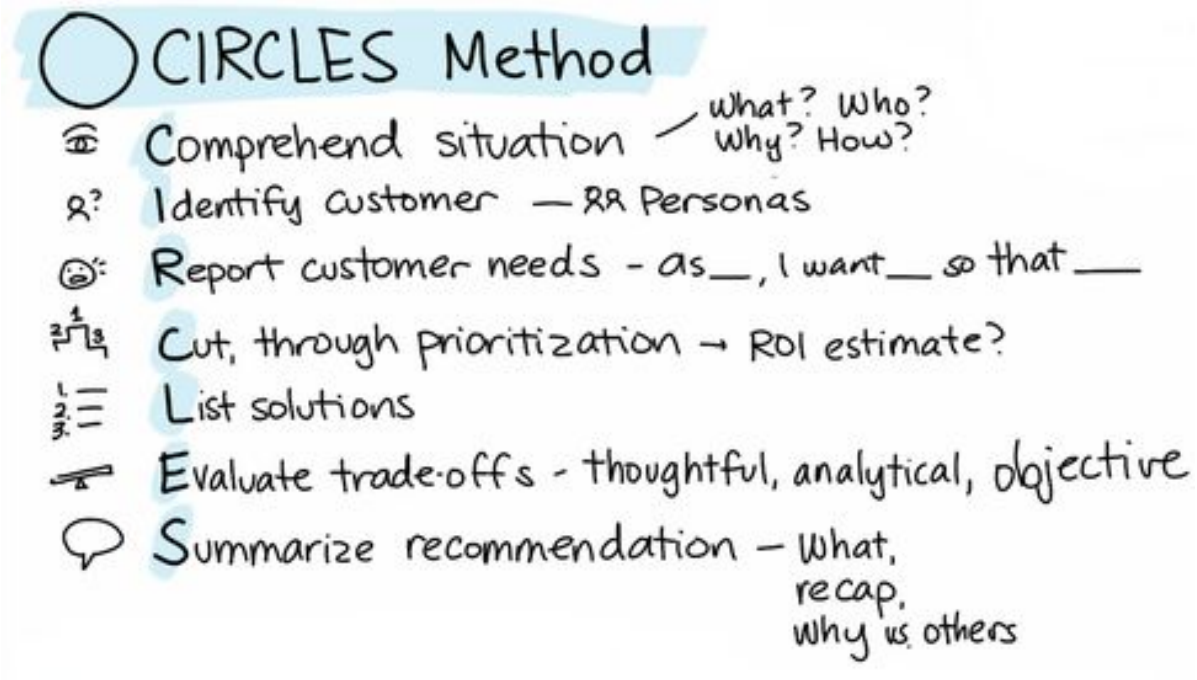
- Partnership
- Recommendations
- Subscriptions
- New tech

CIRCLES Method

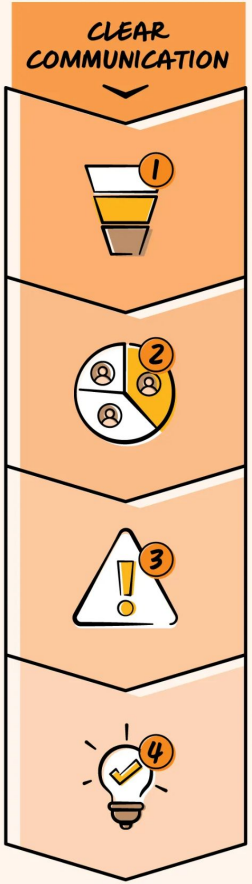
- **C**omprehend situation — What? Who? Why? How?
- **I**dentify customer — Personas
- **R**eport customer needs - as__, I want__ so that__
- **C**ut, through prioritization → ROI estimate?
- **L**ist solutions
- **E**valuate trade-offs - thoughtful, analytical, objective
- **S**ummarize recommendation — What, recap, why vs. others

Product Design - alarm clock

Example: alarm clock for a user who is blind



Typical Product Sense Interview Flow



PRODUCT MOTIVATION

Examine the product's purpose and mission.

< 5 min

SEGMENTATION

Define the audience and prioritize a target segment.

< 10 min

PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

List and prioritize key pain points faced by the chosen segment.

< 10 min

SOLUTION DEVELOPMENT

Brainstorm and prioritize a solution for the problem, including a v1.

< 10 min

Product Strategy

These look like:

- Why did Google decide to enter the cellular service market?
- Why did Facebook acquire Instagram for $1B while Instagram was losing money?
- Should Breville enter the market with a new air fryer?
- Would you launch Amazon in India? Why or why not?

Product Strategy

How to approach

There are a ***lot** of frameworks*. Choose based on topic, and feel free to cherry pick.

- Consumer decision making
  - AIDA: attention / interest / desire / action
  - REAN: reach / engage / activate / nurture
- Marketing
  - 4P's: product / price / promotion / place
- Market entry
  - SWOT: strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, threats
  - 5C's: company / competitors / customers / collaborators / climate
  - Porter's 5 Forces: rivalry / buyer power / supplier power / threat of substitutes / threat of new entrants

Practical tip

Building a reference sheet of common frameworks and considerations for strategy questions can help you internalize the key concepts

Primary on-site interview types

- Behavioral
- Product
  - Strategy
  - Design
- **Analytical**
  - Estimation
  - Debugging
- Technical
  - Algorithms
  - Systems design

Analytical - Estimation

These look like:

- How many golf balls fit in a 747? How many tennis balls fit in a NYC 2 bedroom apartment?
- How much does a school bus weigh?
- What's GMail's annualized ad revenue?
- How much money do people spend on haircuts, worldwide, each year?
- How much could the city of Pittsburgh save by inspecting elevators half as frequently?
- How many people does Apple hire each year?

Analytical - Estimation

How to approach

- **Structure and approach** > the numerical answer
- **Start writing/typing**, you can't keep these in your head
- Choose your numbers wisely to **make the math easy**
- There are usually **many paths** - bonus points for outlining a few... consider **top down vs bottom up**
- You should **know basic #s**

1. **Clarify** the question
2. **Inputs**, figuring out each one
   - It's okay to ask, but offer to figure or estimate
   - Study and learn some common numbers (see sheet)
3. **Equation**
4. **Alternatives**
5. **Answer**
6. **Sanity check**

Analytical - Estimation

***Example*: how much does the US spend on dog food each year?**

Clarify: wet and dry food? Stores or consumers?

Inputs: 300m people in the US, ? dog owners, ? dogs/person, dogs eat 1-2x/day, ? lbs of food / meal, medium-sized bag of dog food is 20 lbs, ? retail cost per bag, most dogs eat dry food

Equation: [# dogs in US] * [food consumption / year] * [cost per unit]

Alternatives: Could back in from market value of the producers, lots of approaches to # dogs

Solve: [# dogs] - break down US pop by income, geo, kids...
→ if, eg, kids: 90% have kids, but 20 years at home, so 30% at any time

Sanity check: what about working dogs? How might our estimate of # dogs be off?

Analytical - Debugging

These look like:

- You're an ads PM at Google. Ad revenue is down 50% YoY. Why?
- You just launched a new shopping feature on Instagram. Conversion rates have trended down since launch. Why?
- Page load times for Yelp have climbed 20% in the last month. What's going on, and what should we do about it?

Analytical - Debugging

Example: you are the PM of YouTube Music. Revenue is down by 25% last month. What's going on, and what should we do?

- Clarify what's going on
  - Mobile vs desktop?
  - Onboarding or churn?
  - Some users? All users? Particular ages, personas, account ages? Geos?
  - Happening across other products?
  - Is this change abrupt or gradual? When did it start?
- Solutions
  - Internal
    - Correct data?
    - A payments or serving issue?
  - External
    - Other product launches?
    - Competitor price/service changes?

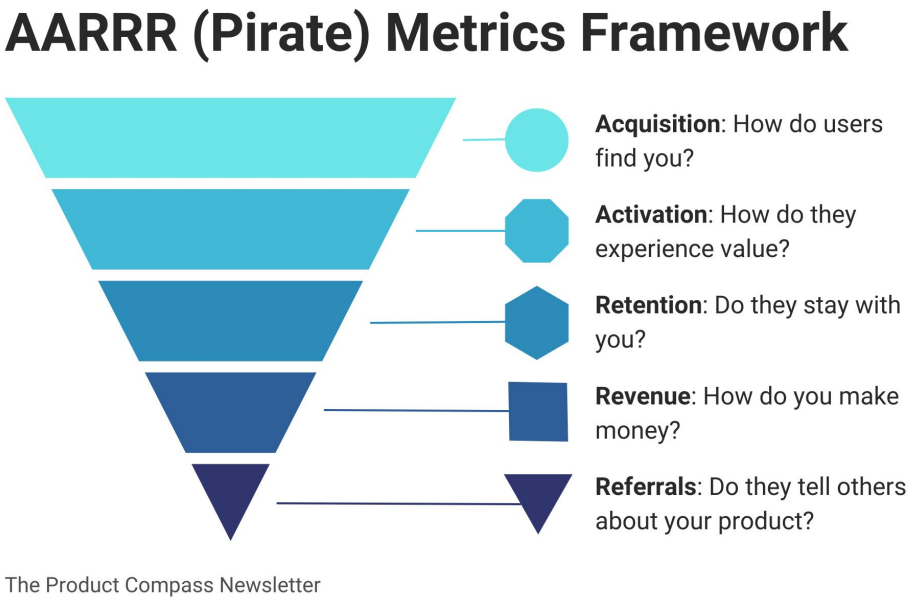
Analytical - Debugging

How to approach

☠️ McClure's Metrics for Pirates ☠️

Don't shortchange investigation at the outset to uncover additional facts

For these questions, **collaboration with the interviewer** is critical



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  - Debugging
- **Technical**
  - Algorithms
  - Systems design

Technical

Goals: validate what's on your resume, ensure you have the technical chops to make good decisions and win the trust of other engineers and PMs.

- *Not* to show you have the best technical chops in the room – as a PM, you'll end up needing to *defer* technical decision-making
- The bar varies widely, so what you should prepare for depends on the company *and sometimes the team/role*
- As engineering masters graduates, you can excel
- Uncommon, but possible, that you will be asked to (pseudo)code solutions on a whiteboard

Technical - Algos

These look like:

- *What O(time) and O(space) does X function use?*
- Given array of positive integers with an empty spot (zero) at the end, insert an element in sorted order
- Given a string, design a function to print all permutations of that string. Assume no duplicate letters
- Implement bubble sort

How to approach:

Usually rudimentary: sort, search, big O tradeoffs.

Before investing time, understand what is required for your target companies. For many, **working familiarity with big O may suffice -** YouTube tutorials, not an algorithms textbook.

Technical - System Design

These look like:

- Design Ticketmaster’s backend infrastructure
- How should YouTube’s video recommendation engine work?
- Design Twitter
- Explain the internet to a 5-year-old
- How would you make this chatbot infrastructure faster?
- What happens, exactly, when I type “columbia.edu” into my web browser and hit enter?

Technical - System Design

How to approach

- An omission from Cracking the PM Interview: you'll need to source your own
- **Keep your PM hat on**: start and end with first principles and good structure.
- **Think aloud** as you go
- **Start simple** before adding complexity
- What concepts might the interviewer be **looking for you to demonstrate**?
  - Scalability: vertical vs horizontal; partitioning/sharding CAP (consistency, availability, partition loss tolerance), caching, read replicas, load balancing
  - API design: context in and out, abuse, scalability

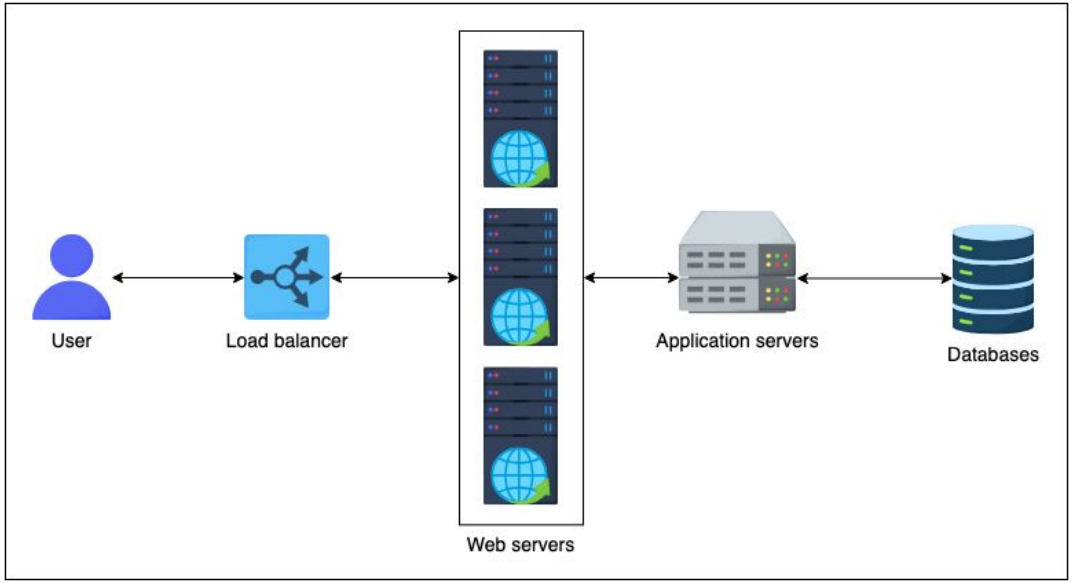
A very simple framework:

- **Requirements**
- **Data** structures
- **System** architecture

Technical - System Design

Example: Design Ticketmaster's backend infrastructure

- Outline your process
- Requirements
  - Functional
  - Non-functional
- Data structures
  - Event
  - Venue
  - Performer
  - Ticket
- Architecture
  - APIs only if required



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Zooming out: no bright lines.

A version of this was one of my favorite deep dive questions:

Zohran Mamdani called and asked you for a proposal to blanket Manhattan with new public WiFi.

- How would you go about it?
  - Technical - Systems design
  - Product - design
  - Overall, how much do they jump to conclusions?
- About how much would it cost to implement your proposal?
  - Analytical - estimation
- What is your overall go/no-go recommendation for the mayor, given the above?
  - Product - strategy

Finally, ask *your* questions!

Don’t forget to have thoughtful questions for the interviewer at the end – doubly so with the hiring manager.

- What excites you most about your job?
- Can you share a bit about your management philosophy? How do you like to work with your team?
- What are some of your biggest challenges today?
- What qualities make someone most likely to succeed here, and why?
- Where have you seen candidates not be great fits, and why?
- If you could change one thing about the organization, what would it be?
- Where do you see the company in 2 years?

Let’s try it!

Pair 1

- **Not yet!**
- 1 minute to find a partner
- 10 minutes each
- New questions each round
- The person who stayed up later last night goes first as interviewee

Interviewee

- You **will not** get through most of the question
- Practice taking a deep breath and structuring the problem.

Interviewer

- Pay **close attention** to the way your partner **does or does not structure** their answer. What would you have done differently?
- If asked, **make up some answers**. For example: “Wet food or dry food or both?” – just pick one! Feel free to say “you pick”, too.

Pair 1 - Round 1

Product strategy
If you were the CEO of Microsoft, what product would you cut, and why?

Product design
Create a mobile phone experience for Disney theme parks.

Analytical - diagnosis
Shopify's global conversion rate (aka, the percentage of customers that start a cart who later complete a purchase) is trending down. What next?

10:00

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Pair 1 - Round 2

Product strategy
Should Uber roll out an ultra-luxury category (eg, Bentley, Rolls Royce)?

Product design
Design a local service recommendation engine – better than Yelp – for consumers.

Analytical - diagnosis
You're a PM at Reddit. The growth rate of posts is slowing. What's going on?

10:00

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Check in!

Pair 2

- **Not yet!**
- 1 minute to find a partner
- 10 minutes each
- New questions each round
- The person who **had the shortest commute to class this afternoon** goes first as interviewee

Interviewee

- You **will not** get through most of the question
- Practice taking a deep breath and structuring the problem.

Interviewer

- Pay **close attention** to the way your partner **does or does not structure** their answer. What would you have done differently?
- If asked, **make up some answers**. For example: “Wet food or dry food or both?” – just pick one! Feel free to say “you pick”, too.

Pair 2 - Round 1

Product strategy
You're a PM at Expedia. They want to start selling train tickets, a new category. What next?

Product design
What would you do to improve Instagram login?

Analytical - estimation
How much does a Manhattan Uber driver make in a day?

10:00

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Pair 2 - Round 2

Product strategy
How would you go about launching Uber in Mexico?

Product design
How would you improve Dropbox? What feature is still missing?

Analytical - estimation
How much does it cost to run GMail, per user, per year?

10:00

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Quick reflection (2 minutes)

- What was that like?
- What do you want to focus on next time you practice?
- What felt like it came naturally?
- What’s something you learned from your partner?

Pick > Land > **Grow**

Tools to win the early days and shape a long-term career arc.

Negotiate your offer

Offers typically consist of the following. Assume that **everything** is negotiable:

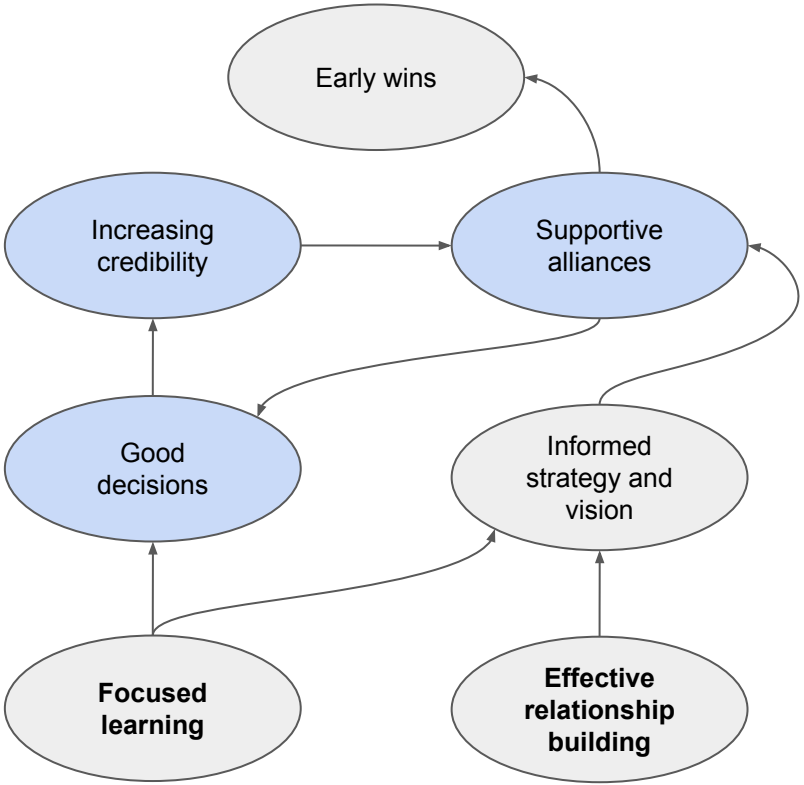
- Starting date
- Signing bonus
- **Starting level** ← *big tech - see levels.fyi*
- Base salary
- Equity grant with vesting schedule
  - At startups, cash vs equity is a common tradeoff
- Mostly for execs:
  - Goal-based compensation
  - Acceleration clauses and other specialized equity tools

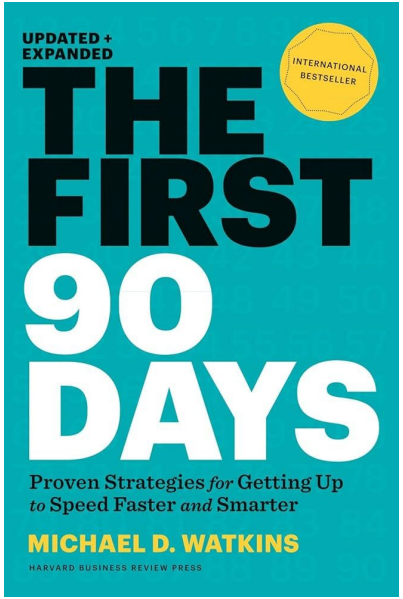
Don't accept the first offer you get!

Negotiate **differential value**, not just money. Think creatively about win-wins:

- A travel or training stipend
- An extra week leave, unpaid
- A home office refit stipend

The virtuous cycle of transitions





Find a mentor

Choose wisely - a **significant commitment** to get real value:

- Formal mentor matching platforms
- But almost anywhere within or outside of an organization can be a good fit

You are **pitching for their time**:

- **Personality** fit is a requirement
- Work with **their schedule**
- Demonstrate your **commitment**:
  - Pitch on *why them*
  - Come prepared with a set of *expectations* for your work together
  - Consistently prioritize it

Pick the growth that matters to you

- **Promotion / increasing responsibility**
  - Expectations - discuss future success then assemble resources and a plan to get there.
  - Identify - find the highest-priority projects – close to the core or new frontiers - within or without
  - Move (if needed) - express explicit interest and find ways to demonstrate value (eg, volunteer)
- **More time outside of work**
  - Look for well-established areas of an organization
  - Crowdsource from colleagues once inside, can be very manager/team/cycle-dependent
- **Higher compensation**
  - At big companies, competing offers are high leverage for the same role, as long as you have a strong performance track record
  - Consider moving companies - new signing bonus
- **Variety**
  - Variety can be an asset as much as specialization – in particular for some leadership roles.
  - Being inside an organization is the best way to move - coffee chats are easy
  - Get creative in linking what you've done to what you want to do next

Today, we covered:

(1) **Pick**

What product management is and is not, theoretically and practically, to decide if PM is a good fit for you and your goals.

(2) **Land**

The three cornerstones of landing a job in product management, with a focus on interview skills, plus a few mini practice interviews under your belt.

(3) **Grow**

Tools to win the early days and shape a long-term career arc.

Thank you,

future PMs!

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